PART I

Pitch

Every note is higher or lower than another. This part starts with the keyboard you can see and touch, moves to the staff where those keys are written, and ends with the families of notes, scales and keys, that whole pieces are built from.

1 **Keyboard** high and low, the patterns › 2 **Staff** lines, spaces and clefs › 3 **Note names** reading every note › 4 **Sharps and flats** the black keys › 5 **Intervals** the distance between notes › 6 **Scales and keys** notes in families

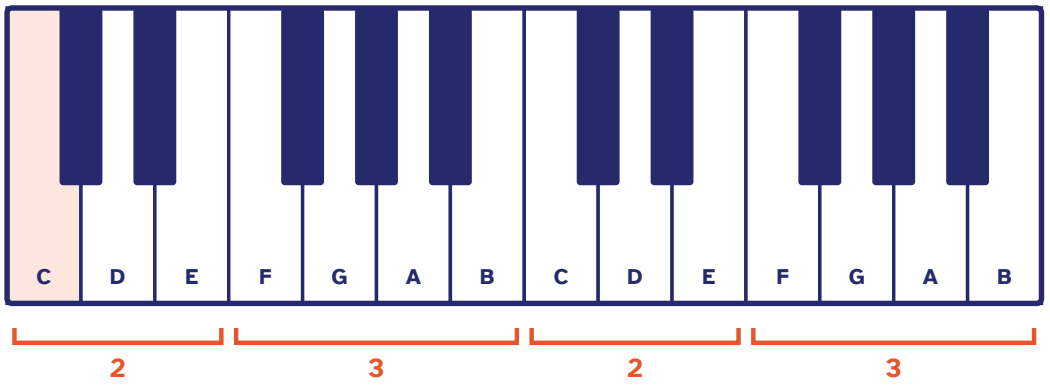
IN THIS PART

The keyboard 22
The staff and the clefs 23
Reading the notes 24
Sharps, flats and naturals 25
Tones, semitones and intervals 26
Scales 27
Keys and key signatures 28

PART I · PITCH · 1

The keyboard

Keys to the **left** sound **lower**; keys to the **right** sound **higher**. The black keys come in groups of **two** and **three**, and that pattern repeats all the way along: it is how you find every note.



The white keys

The white keys are named with seven letters, **A B C D E F G**, then the letters start again. **C** is the white key just left of each group of two black keys; **F** is just left of each group of three.

Middle C and octaves

Middle C is the C nearest the middle of the keyboard, usually right in front of you. From one C to the next is an **octave**: eight white keys, counting both. A full piano has 88 keys, from A at the bottom to C at the top.

Words to know

TERM	MEANING	FIRST MET
pitch	how high or low a sound is	Level 0
octave	the distance from one note to the next with the same name (8 white keys)	Level 0
semitone	from one key to the very next key, black or white	Level 0
tone	two semitones	Level 0
register	a part of the keyboard: low, middle or high	Level 0

WATCH OUT

- × Finding C by counting from the bottom: find a group of two black keys and look just to the left.
- × Calling every white-to-white step a tone: E–F and B–C have no black key between them, so they are semitones.

SEE ALSO

The staff p. 23 · Tones and semitones p. 26

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Level 0 · Keyboard · Online: Keyboard patterns, Musical alphabet

PART I · PITCH · 2

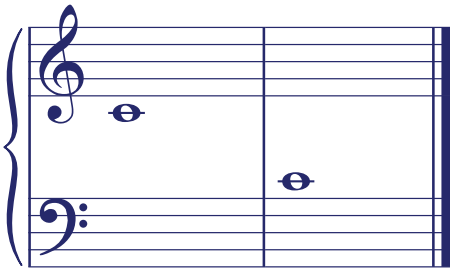
The staff and the clefs

Music is written on a **staff** (or stave) of five lines and four spaces. Lines and spaces are counted from the **bottom**. Higher notes sit higher on the staff. A **clef** at the start tells you which notes the lines and spaces stand for.

CLEF	NAME	HOW IT SHOWS ITS NOTE	FIRST MET
𝄞	**treble clef** (G clef)	curls round the line for G (line 2)	Level 0
𝄢	**bass clef** (F clef)	its two dots sit either side of the line for F (line 4)	Level 0
𝄡	**alto clef** (C clef)	its centre marks middle C, on line 3	Level 2

The grand staff

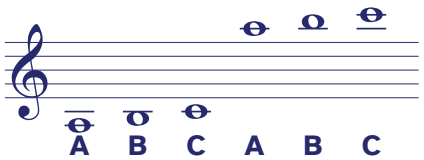
Piano music uses two staves joined by a brace: the treble staff, usually for the right hand, above the bass staff, usually for the left. **Middle C** sits between them on a short line of its own, and can be written in either staff.



Middle C written in the treble staff (left) and in the bass staff (right): the same key.

Ledger lines

Notes above or below the staff are written on short extra lines called **ledger lines**, spaced exactly like the staff lines.



Octave signs

SIGN	MEANING
8va	play an octave higher than written; a dotted line shows how long
8vb	play an octave lower
15ma	play two octaves higher
loco	back where it is written

Level ½. Octave signs save writing many ledger lines.

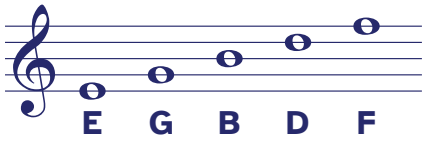
SEE ALSO
Reading the notes p. 24

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Level 0 · The staff · Online: Library › Staff and clefs

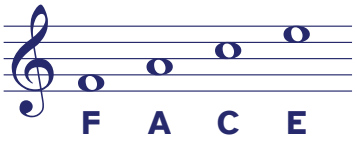
PART I · PITCH · 3

Reading the notes

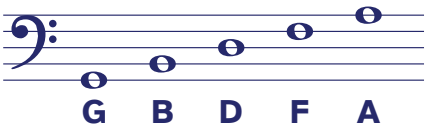
Each line and space has one letter name. Learn them in two ways: by the patterns below, and by a few **landmark notes** you can find instantly and count from.



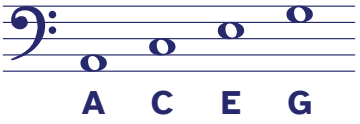
Treble clef: the lines



Treble clef: the spaces



Bass clef: the lines

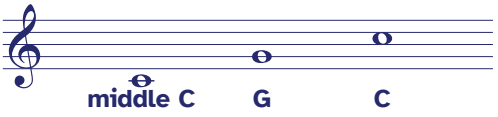


Bass clef: the spaces

STAFF	NOTES, BOTTOM TO TOP	TO REMEMBER
Treble lines	E G B D F	*Every Good Boy Deserves Fun*
Treble spaces	F A C E	spells *FACE*
Bass lines	G B D F A	*Great Big Dragon Flies Away*
Bass spaces	A C E G	*All Cows Eat Grass*

Landmark notes

Find these first: middle C, the G the treble clef curls round, the F between the bass clef's dots. Any other note is a step or a skip away. A **step** moves from a line to the next space (or space to line); a **skip** jumps from line to line or space to space.



Treble clef: middle C, the G it curls round, the C in the third space



Bass clef: the C in the second space, the F between its dots, middle C

WATCH OUT

- × Reading the bass clef with treble names: the same position has a different name in each clef.
- × Counting lines from the top: always count from the bottom.
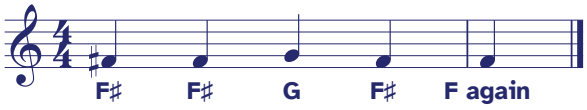
PART I · PITCH · 4

Sharps, flats and naturals

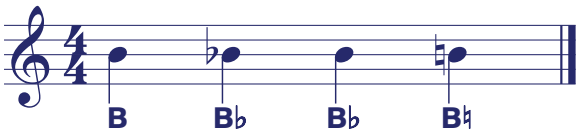
An **accidental** written before a note changes its pitch by a semitone. On the keyboard, a sharp usually means the black key to the right, a flat the black key to the left.

SIGN	NAME	WHAT IT DOES	FIRST MET
♯	sharp	raises a note by a semitone	Level 0
♭	flat	lowers a note by a semitone	Level 0
♮	natural	cancels a sharp or flat	Level ½
𝄪	double sharp	raises by two semitones	Level 4
𝄫	double flat	lowers by two semitones	Level 4

An accidental lasts for the bar



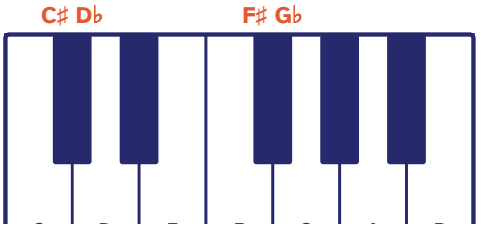
The sharp still counts later in the bar; after the bar line, F is F again.



A natural cancels the flat for the rest of the bar.

One key, two names

Every black key has two names: the key between F and G is both **F♯** and **G♭**. Notes that sound the same but are written differently are **enharmonic**. White keys can have sharp or flat names too: **E♯** is F, **C♭** is B.



WATCH OUT

- × Forgetting that an accidental carries on through the bar.
- × Thinking every sharp is a black key: E♯ and B♯ are white keys.

SEE ALSO

Keys and key signatures p. 28

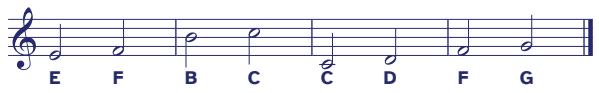
PRACTISE IT

Workbook Levels 0–½ · Accidentals · Online: Library › Signs

PART I · PITCH · 5

Tones, semitones and intervals

A **semitone** is the very next key; a **tone** is two semitones. An **interval** is the distance between two notes. Its **number** comes from counting letter names, both ends included; its **quality** from counting semitones.



E–F and B–C are semitones; C–D and F–G are tones.



Melodic: one note after the other. Harmonic: together.

Interval numbers from C



Size in semitones

NUMBER	SMALLER	MAIN	WIDER	FIRST MET
unison	0			Level 1
2nd	1 (minor)	2 (major)		Level 1
3rd	3 (minor)	4 (major)		Level ½
4th		5 (perfect)	6 (augmented)	Level 1
5th	6 (diminished)	7 (perfect)		Level 1
6th	8 (minor)	9 (major)		Level 2
7th	10 (minor)	11 (major)		Level 2
octave		12 (perfect)		Level 1

Augmented: a semitone wider than major or perfect. Diminished: a semitone narrower than minor or perfect (Level 5). Six semitones is the tritone. Turned upside down, the numbers add to 9 and major and minor swap.
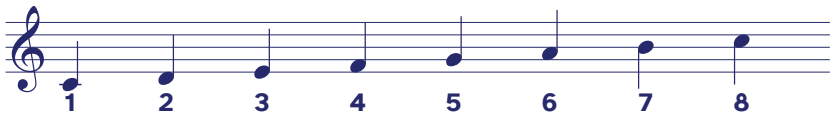
SEE ALSO
Scales p. 27 · Chords p. 50

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Levels 1–2 · Intervals · Online: Library › Intervals

PART I · PITCH · 6

Scales
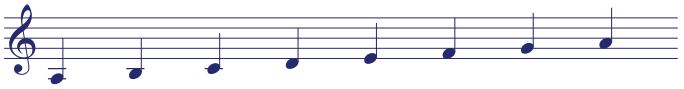
A **scale** is a ladder of notes from one key note up to the next, in a fixed pattern of tones (T) and semitones (S). The pattern, not the starting note, makes a scale major or minor.
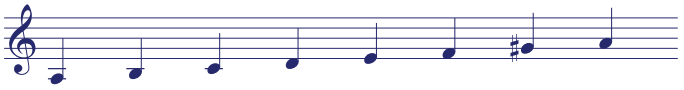


C major: T T S T T T S. The semitones fall between 3–4 and 7–8.

SCALE	STEPS	FIRST MET
major	T T S T T T S	Level ½
natural minor	T S T T S T T	Level ½
harmonic minor	T S T T S T+S S	Level ½
melodic minor (up)	T S T T T T S; down as the natural minor	Level 2
chromatic	every semitone	Level 2
pentatonic (black keys)	T T T+S T T+S	Level 0
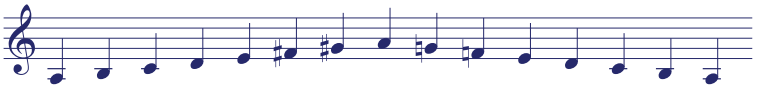
A minor in three forms



Natural: the notes of C major, from A to A.



Harmonic: the 7th raised a semitone (G♯).



Melodic: 6th and 7th raised going up, lowered coming down.

Degree names

1 tonic · **2** supertonic · **3** mediant · **4** subdominant · **5** dominant · **6** submediant · **7** leading note

Relative major and minor

Every major key shares its notes and key signature with a minor key three semitones lower: its **relative minor**. C major and A minor; G major and E minor.

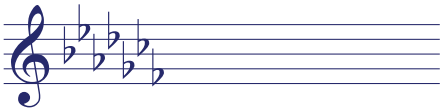
PART I · PITCH · 7

Keys and key signatures

A **key signature** at the start of each line lists the sharps or flats the piece uses throughout, so they do not have to be written before every note. They always appear in the same order.



Sharps: F C G D A E B. The key note is a semitone above the last sharp.



Flats: B E A D G C F. From two flats, the second-last flat names the key.

MAJOR	RELATIVE MINOR	SIGNATURE	FIRST MET
C major	A minor	—	Level ½
G major	E minor	1♯	Level ½
D major	B minor	2♯	Level 1
A major	F♯ minor	3♯	Level 3
E major	C♯ minor	4♯	Level 4
B major	G♯ minor	5♯	Level 4
F major	D minor	1♭	Level ½
B♭ major	G minor	2♭	Level 1
E♭ major	C minor	3♭	Level 3
A♭ major	F minor	4♭	Level 4
D♭ major	B♭ minor	5♭	Level 4

Six and seven sharps or flats (F♯, C♯, G♭, C♭ major and their minors) come at Levels 4–6.

WATCH OUT

- × Forgetting the key signature halfway down the page: it applies to every line and every octave.
- × Naming a minor key from its signature alone: check the last note and look for a raised 7th.

SEE ALSO

Scales p. 27 · Related keys p. 30

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Levels ½–4 · Keys · Online: Scale finder, Library › Keys

PART II

Time

Music moves through time. Underneath it runs a steady **pulse**; the pulse is grouped into **bars**; and every note and rest takes a measured share of it. This part goes from that big picture down to the length of a single note.

1 **Pulse** — the steady beat underneath

›

2 **Bar** — beats in groups of 2, 3 or 4

›

3 **Time signature** — how many beats, and which note is one beat

›

4 **Note values** — how long each sound lasts

›

5 **Rhythm** — the pattern of long and short

IN THIS PART

Pulse, tempo and the bar 36
Notes and rests 37
How long is a note? 38
Time signatures 39
Compound and irregular time 40
Rhythm: groups and upbeats 41
Rhythm: off the beat 42

PART II · TIME · 1

Pulse, tempo and the bar

Under almost every piece runs a **pulse**: a steady beat, like a heartbeat or a clock. Its speed is the **tempo**. Beats are grouped into **bars**, and the first beat of every bar is the strongest.

Tempo

Tempo is measured in beats per minute. A **metronome mark** at the top of the music shows it: ♩ **= 60** means 60 crotchet beats a minute, one beat a second. ♩ **= 120** is twice as fast. Tempo words such as *Andante* and *Allegro* are on page 70.

Strong and weak beats

BEATS	PATTERN	FEELS LIKE
2	**Strong** weak	a march
3	**Strong** weak weak	a waltz
4	**Strong** weak **medium** weak	most songs

Bars and bar lines

SIGN	NAME	MEANING
	bar line	divides the music into bars
	double bar line	marks the end of a section, or a change of key, time signature or tempo
	final bar line	marks the end of the piece
	repeat signs	play the passage between them again; if there is no start sign, go back to the beginning

Counting



Three bars of 3/4. Every beat is counted, even inside a long note: the coral number is where you play, the grey numbers are the beats you hold.

Count aloud at one speed, a little louder on beat 1. With a metronome, start slower than you think and speed up only when the passage is steady.

WATCH OUT

- × Speeding up in the easy bars and slowing down in the hard ones: choose a tempo you can keep in the hardest bar.
- × Counting the notes instead of the beats.

SEE ALSO
Time signatures p. 39 · Tempo words p. 70

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Level 0 · Pulse · Online: Metronome

PART II · TIME · 2

Notes and rests

A note's shape shows how long it lasts: each plain note lasts **half as long** as the one above it. Every note has a **rest** of the same length, a silence counted just as carefully as a sound.

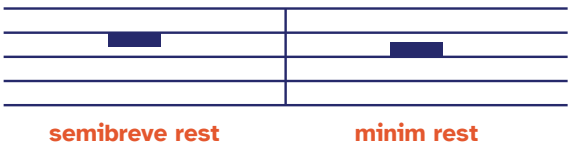
NOTE	REST	NAME	ALSO CALLED	BEATS*	FIRST MET
		**breve**	double whole note	**8**	Level 4
		**dotted semibreve**	dotted whole note	**6**	*Extra*
		**semibreve**	whole note	**4**	Level 0
		**dotted minim**	dotted half note	**3**	Level 0
		**minim**	half note	**2**	Level 0
		**dotted crotchet**	dotted quarter note	**1½**	Level ½
		**crotchet**	quarter note	**1**	Level 0
		**dotted quaver**	dotted eighth note	**¾**	Level 3
		**quaver**	eighth note	**½**	Level 0
		**semiquaver**	sixteenth note	**¼**	Level 2
		**demisemiquaver**	32nd note	**⅛**	*Extra*
		**hemidemisemiquaver**	64th note	**1/16**	*Extra*

* With the crotchet as one beat, as in 2/4, 3/4 and 4/4. *Extra*: beyond Level 8.

Parts of a note

The **head** sits on a line or in a space. A **stem** goes up on the right of the head or down on the left. **Flags** on the stem halve the value each time; groups of quavers are joined by **beams** instead of flags.

Which rest is which?
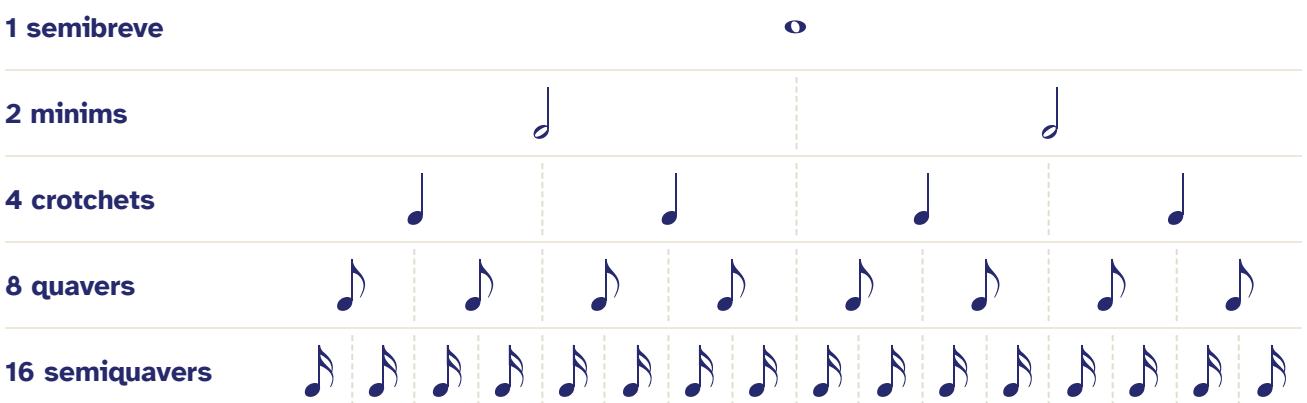


The semibreve rest **hangs** below the fourth line; the minim rest **sits** on the middle line.

PART II · TIME · 2
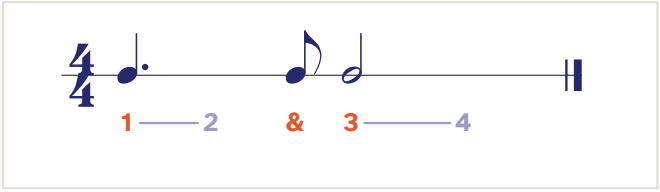
How long is a note?

Each row lasts exactly as long as the row above it: the same stretch of time, cut in half again and again.



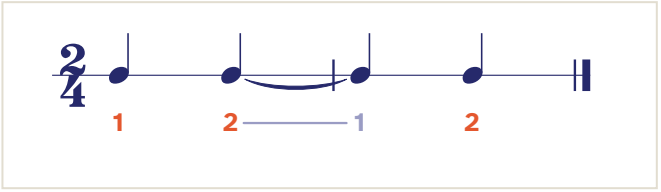
The dot

A dot adds **half the note's value**: a dotted minim lasts 2 + 1 = 3 beats; a dotted crotchet 1 + ½ = 1½. A **double dot** adds half, then a quarter: a double-dotted minim lasts 2 + 1 + ½ = 3½.



The tie

A curve joining two notes **of the same pitch** makes one longer sound: play the first, hold through the second. Ties can cross a bar line, where a dot cannot.



TIE OR SLUR?

The same curve over notes of **different** pitches is a **slur**: play them smoothly joined (legato). Same pitch: a tie. Different pitches: a slur.

Rests in a bar



✓ The silence on beats 3–4 is one minim rest; a whole silent bar takes a semibreve rest, in any time signature.



× In 4/4, a minim rest on beats 2–3 hides the middle of the bar: write two crotchet rests.

SEE ALSO

Time signatures p. 39 · Rhythm p. 41

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Level 0 · Note values · Online: Library › Notes and rests

PART II · TIME · 3

Time signatures

Two numbers at the start of the music. The **top number** says how many counts are in each bar; the **bottom number** says which note gets one count.

The bottom number

BOTTOM	NOTE	ONE COUNT IS A	FIRST MET
2		minim	Level 3
4		crotchet	Level 0
8		quaver	Level 1
16		semiquaver	*Extra*

SIMPLE OR COMPOUND?

In **simple time** each beat divides into **two**. In **compound time** each beat is a dotted note and divides into **three**.

Quick test: a top number of 6, 9 or 12 means compound. Divide it by 3 to find the beats: 6/8 has 2, 9/8 has 3, 12/8 has 4.

Simple time: each beat divides in two

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
2/4	2 crotchets	Level 0
3/4	3 crotchets	Level 0
4/4 C	4 crotchets (the C sign: common time)	Level 0
2/2 ¢	2 minims (the cut C: cut common time)	Level 3
3/2	3 minims	Level 3
4/2	4 minims	*Extra*
3/8	3 quavers	Level 3

Changing time signature

A new time signature can appear in the middle of a piece, right after a bar line; it holds until the next one. A time signature is written only once, not on every line.

WATCH OUT

- × Reading 6/8 as six beats: at most speeds it moves in two.
- × Mixing up 3/4 and 6/8: both hold six quavers, grouped differently (page 40).

SEE ALSO

Pulse and the bar p. 36 · Compound time p. 40

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Level 0 · Time signatures · Online: Library › Time signatures

PART II · TIME · 3

Compound and irregular time

Compound time has dotted beats that divide into three; irregular time has five or seven counts, grouped unevenly. (9/4, 12/4 and the /16 signatures exist but are rare.)

Compound time
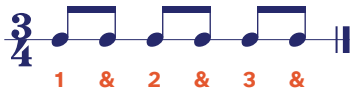
TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
6/8	2 dotted crotchets	Level 1
9/8	3 dotted crotchets	Level 3
12/8	4 dotted crotchets	Level 3
6/4	2 dotted minims	Level 4

Counting 6/8

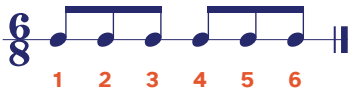


Slowly, count all six quavers. At speed, feel two beats, on 1 and 4: “1 & a, 2 & a”.

3/4 or 6/8?



3/4: six quavers in three twos



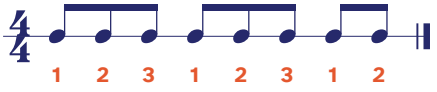
6/8: six quavers in two threes

Irregular time

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
5/4	5 crotchets: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	Level 0
7/4	7 crotchets: 4 + 3 or 3 + 4	*Extra*
5/8	5 quavers: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3	*Extra*
7/8	7 quavers: 2 + 2 + 3 or 3 + 2 + 2	*Extra*

UNEVEN GROUPS IN 4/4

Many dances keep 4/4 but group the eight quavers 3 + 3 + 2: “1 2 3, 1 2 3, 1 2”.
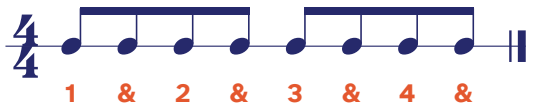


PART II · TIME · 4

Rhythm: groups and upbeats

Rhythm is the pattern of long and short sounds over the pulse. The pulse stays steady; the rhythm moves around it. The way notes are grouped on the page shows where the beats are.

Grouping with beams

Beams join the notes of **one beat**, so the beats stay visible. In 4/4 a beam may cover beats 1–2 or 3–4, but never cross the middle of the bar. In compound time, quavers are beamed in threes.



✓ The middle of the bar can be seen.



× A beam across beats 2–3 hides it.

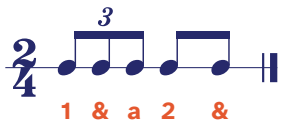
The upbeat (anacrusis)

A piece can begin **before** the first full bar, with one or more notes called an upbeat or anacrusis. The last bar is then short by the same amount, so the two together make one full bar. Count the missing beats in silence before you start.
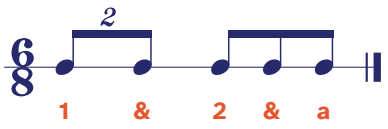


Count “1 2” silently, then play on 3.

Triplets and duplets



Triplet: three notes in the time of two.

Level 2. Three exactly equal notes.



Duplet: two notes in the time of three, in compound time.

Level 2.

Counting smaller values



Crotchet, two quavers, four semiquavers and a triplet (“1 & a”): one beat each.

PART II · TIME · 4

Rhythm: off the beat

Once the pulse is secure, rhythm can pull against it. Every one of these effects needs a steady beat underneath.

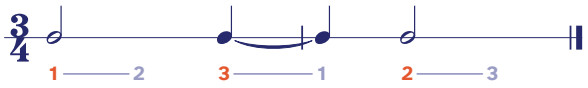
Syncopation



The crotchet starts on “&” and is held through beat 2.

Level 4. Feel beat 2 even though nothing is played on it.

Hemiola



Two bars of 3/4 felt as three minims.

Level 4. Common at cadences in Baroque dances.

Swing Level ½

Common from the first pieces: jazz, blues and many easy modern pieces are marked *swing*. Pairs of quavers are written evenly but played **long–short**, like the first and last notes of a triplet.

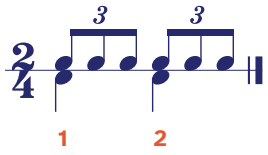


Written



Played

Polyrhythm Level 7



Three against two: a triplet above, two crotchets below, starting together.

Rubato Extra

Time is stretched and then given back, for expression: the music leans into a phrase and catches up after it. The pulse always returns. Marked *rubato*, or simply part of the style in much Romantic music.

WATCH OUT

- × Rushing the short notes after a long one: keep counting inside the long note.
- × Playing a triplet unevenly: three equal notes, not two quick and one long.
- × Letting syncopation drag the pulse: tap the beat with your foot.

SEE ALSO
Notes and rests p. 37 · Words for how to play p. 70

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Levels ½–4 · Rhythm · Online: Rhythm clock